

CMS Healthcare Terminology Guide

Selected terms from the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) Glossary, organized for healthcare consulting, resource navigation, and intern onboarding.

Source: CMS Glossary - <https://www.cms.gov/glossary>

Prepared: June 26, 2026. Upload this PDF into your website assets folder and link it from the Healthcare Terminology Dictionary section.

Quick Category Index

Appeals / Compliance: 1
Clinical: 1
Clinical / Long-Term Care: 1
Clinical / Technology: 1
Coding / Revenue Cycle: 1
Compliance / Technology: 2
Data / Analytics: 1
Finance / Medicare: 7
General Healthcare: 2
Long-Term Care: 1
Medicaid / Managed Care: 1
Medicare Enrollment: 1
Patient Rights: 3
Payer / Benefits: 1
Payer / Pharmacy: 1
Policy / Compliance: 1
Quality / Compliance: 3
Revenue Cycle / Medicare: 3

CMS / Governance: 1
Clinical / Data: 1
Clinical / Revenue Cycle: 1
Clinical Operations: 1
Compliance / Revenue Cycle: 1
Coverage / Payer: 1
ERP / Technology: 1
Finance / Operations: 1
General Healthcare / Compliance: 1
Long-Term Services: 1
Medicare Advantage: 1
Medicare Operations: 1
Patient Safety: 1
Payer / Medicare Advantage: 1
Payer / Provider Network: 1
Policy / Medicare: 1
Quality / Medicare: 1
Standards / Technology: 1

1. 508 / 508 Compliance

Bucket: General Healthcare / Compliance

CMS is bound to producing 508 compliant applications. Section 508 refers to accessibility requirements for federal electronic and information technology.

2. A Tier

Bucket: Payer / Pharmacy

A specific list of drugs. A plan may have several tiers, and the copayment amount depends on which tier a drug is listed.

3. Abstract

Bucket: Clinical / Data

The collection of information from the medical record by hard copy or electronic instrument.

4. Abuse

Bucket: Compliance / Revenue Cycle

Improper behaviors or billing practices, including billing for non-covered services, misusing claim codes, or inappropriately allocating costs on a cost report.

5. Abuse (Personal)

Bucket: Patient Safety

When another person does something on purpose that causes mental or physical harm or pain.

6. Access

Bucket: General Healthcare

A person's ability to get needed medical care and services.

7. Accessibility of Services

Bucket: General Healthcare

A person's ability to get medical care and services when needed.

8. Accessory Dwelling Unit (ADU)

Bucket: Long-Term Services

A separate housing arrangement within a single-family home that includes a complete living unit with a private kitchen and bath.

9. Accreditation

Bucket: Quality / Compliance

An evaluative process in which a healthcare organization is examined by an external accrediting body to determine whether it meets defined criteria.

10. Accreditation Cycle for M+C Deeming

Bucket: Quality / Medicare

The duration of CMS recognition of the validity of an accrediting organization's determination that a Medicare+Choice organization is fully accredited.

11. Accreditation for Deeming

Bucket: Quality / Compliance

Some states use findings of private accreditation organizations to supplement or substitute for state oversight of certain quality-related standards.

12. Accreditation for Participation

Bucket: Medicaid / Managed Care

A state requirement that plans must be accredited to participate in the Medicaid managed care program.

13. Accredited (Accreditation)

Bucket: Quality / Compliance

Having a seal of approval; a facility or healthcare organization has met quality standards set by nationally recognized groups.

14. Accredited Standards Committee

Bucket: Standards / Technology

An organization accredited by ANSI for the development of American National Standards.

15. Act / Law / Statute

Bucket: Policy / Compliance

Legislation that passed through Congress and was signed by the President or passed over a veto.

16. Activities of Daily Living (ADL)

Bucket: Clinical / Long-Term Care

Activities usually done during a normal day, such as getting in and out of bed, dressing, bathing, eating, and using the bathroom.

17. Actual Charge

Bucket: Revenue Cycle / Medicare

The amount a doctor or supplier charges for a medical service or supply. It is often more than the Medicare-approved amount.

18. Actuarial Balance

Bucket: Finance / Medicare

The difference between the summarized income rate and summarized cost rate over a specified valuation period.

19. Actuarial Deficit

Bucket: Finance / Medicare

A negative actuarial balance.

20. Actuarial Rates

Bucket: Finance / Medicare

One half of the expected monthly SMI program cost for aged or disabled enrollees for the period the rate is in effect.

21. Actuarial Soundness

Bucket: Finance / Medicare

A measure of the adequacy of Hospital Insurance and Supplementary Medical Insurance financing based on the difference between trust fund assets and liabilities for specified periods.

22. Actuarial Status

Bucket: Finance / Medicare

A measure of financing adequacy based on the difference between assets and liabilities at the end of the periods for which financing was established.

23. Additional Benefits

Bucket: Medicare Advantage

Health care services not covered by Medicare, or reductions in premiums or cost sharing for Medicare-covered services, offered by a Medicare Advantage organization.

24. Adjusted Average Per Capita Cost (AAPCC)

Bucket: Finance / Medicare

An estimate of how much Medicare will spend in a year for an average beneficiary.

25. Adjusted Community Rating (ACR)

Bucket: Payer / Medicare Advantage

How premium rates are decided based on members' use of benefits rather than individual use of benefits.

26. Administrative Code Sets

Bucket: ERP / Technology

Code sets that characterize a general business situation rather than a medical condition or service. Under HIPAA these are sometimes called non-clinical or non-medical code sets.

27. Administrative Costs

Bucket: Finance / Operations

A general term referring to Medicare, Medicaid, and CMS administrative costs, including program administration expenses.

28. Administrative Data

Bucket: Data / Analytics

Information collected, processed, and stored in automated information systems, including enrollment, eligibility, claims, and managed care encounters.

29. Administrative Expenses

Bucket: Finance / Medicare

Expenses incurred by HHS and the Treasury in administering the SMI program and related contribution collection provisions.

30. Administrative Law Judge (ALJ)

Bucket: Appeals / Compliance

A hearings officer who presides over appeal conflicts between providers or beneficiaries and Medicare contractors.

31. Administrative Services Only

Bucket: Payer / Benefits

An arrangement where a self-insured entity contracts with a third-party administrator to administer a health plan.

32. Administrative Simplification

Bucket: Compliance / Technology

The HIPAA provisions authorizing HHS to adopt standards for transactions, code sets, standard identifiers, and privacy/security protections.

33. Administrative Simplification Compliance Act

Bucket: Compliance / Technology

A 2001 law that extended HIPAA electronic and code set transaction compliance timing and addressed payment of paper claims under certain conditions.

34. Administrator

Bucket: CMS / Governance

The Administrator of the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services.

35. Admission Date

Bucket: Clinical / Revenue Cycle

The date the patient was admitted for inpatient care, outpatient service, start of care, or hospice election effective date.

36. Admitting Diagnosis Code

Bucket: Coding / Revenue Cycle

A code indicating the patient's diagnosis at admission.

37. Admitting Physician

Bucket: Clinical Operations

The doctor responsible for admitting a patient to a hospital or other inpatient health facility.

38. Adult Living Care Facility

Bucket: Long-Term Care

A residential care facility for beneficiaries who cannot live alone but do not need around-the-clock skilled medical services.

39. Advance Beneficiary Notice (ABN)

Bucket: Revenue Cycle / Medicare

A notice a doctor or supplier should give when Medicare is expected to deny payment for an item or service. If properly given and signed, the beneficiary may be responsible for payment.

40. Advance Coverage Decision

Bucket: Coverage / Payer

A decision made by a Private Fee-for-Service Plan about whether it will pay for a certain service.

41. Advance Directive (Health Care)

Bucket: Patient Rights

A written document prepared ahead of time that states how medical decisions should be made if a person loses the ability to make decisions.

42. Advance Directives

Bucket: Patient Rights

Written documents stating how medical decisions should be made if a person loses decision-making ability. They may include a Living Will and Durable Power of Attorney for health care.

43. Advisory Council on Social Security

Bucket: Policy / Medicare

A council historically appointed to study and review the financial status of the OASDI and Medicare programs.

44. Advocate

Bucket: Patient Rights

A person who gives support or protects a person's rights.

45. Affiliated Contractor

Bucket: Medicare Operations

A Medicare carrier, fiscal intermediary, or other contractor that shares some or all of a program safeguard contractor's jurisdiction.

46. Affiliated Provider

Bucket: Payer / Provider Network

A health care provider or facility that is paid by a health plan to provide services to plan members.

47. Aged Enrollee

Bucket: Medicare Enrollment

An individual age 65 or older who is enrolled in the SMI program.

48. Albumin

Bucket: Clinical

A simple protein in the blood; its level may reflect protein intake from food.

49. Algorithm

Bucket: Clinical / Technology

A rule or procedure with conditional logic for solving a problem or completing a task; in health care it can support guideline or criteria evaluation.

50. Allowed Charge

Bucket: Revenue Cycle / Medicare

The charge determined by a carrier for a covered SMI medical service or supply.

Suggested Website Link Text

Download CMS Healthcare Terminology Guide

Suggested HTML path after upload:

./assets/CMS_Healthcare_Terminology_Guide.pdf